After reading the report I had shared with her on a piece of paper, she looked at me with disappointment on her face. ‘Start rolling,’ she commanded. I started front-rolling on the floor, but I was quite sure I hadn’t made any mistakes in finalizing the report that night. It had been more than ten days that I had started reporting to the WUO, and even though I tried my best to not disappoint her, I ended up making one mistake or another. Sometimes I would get punished for writing the report in a wrong format or for leaving an error in the report or for showing up outside her cabin two minutes early or late. Then there were times when I would simply doze off while making the report and not show up at all. My fellow cadets had started joking that the floor outside the WUO’s cabin always shone ‘from Gunjan’s rolling’. But that night, I was sure there was no mistake. After about fifteen minutes of rolling and push-ups, the WUO sent me to my cabin after saying that she did not like my handwriting and that I should improve it. It was just another night in the life of a flight cadet!

We were halfway through the first term when the eighth check sortie knocked on our doors. During flying training, there are certain check sorties scheduled at different stages to scrutinize the progress of a cadet before they impart further training. This was one such check sortie, which we were supposed to fly with the chief flying instructor (CFI). Anuradha, Supreet and I were trained by one of the best instructors in the academy, Sqn Ldr S.K. Borbora, a short-built, generous, round-faced Assamese officer. But when it came to flying with the CFI Wing Commander S.S. Patil, even the best trainees broke out into cold sweat. Though professional and energetic, Wing Commander Patil was also known among the cadets for blowing his top inside the cockpit if someone failed to perform well. If being short-tempered wasn’t all, his austerity was exemplary. Getting into his bad books had often led to cadets getting demoted or even thrown out of the flying branch altogether. The CFI always demanded meticulous performances from cadets to achieve certain benchmarks in the flying training under his command. When the day of my eighth check sortie came, I was quite sure I’d end up disappointing the CFI, just as I always disappointed my squadron’s WUO. Little did I know then that the WUO’s strict attitude